

ECON 2555A: Intermediate Microeconomics

Spring 2026

Bowdoin College

1 Course Information

Instructor: Weizheng Lai

Contact: By email w.lai@bowdoin.edu

Lecture Time: TuTh 11:40 AM–1:05 PM

Lecture Location: Hubbard Hall 213 (Pickering Room)

Office Hours: TuTh 10:30–11:30 AM & Th 4:30–5:30 PM, Hubbard 8; or by appointment

Course Website: Canvas

Learning Assistant: Evie Hamer (ehamer@bowdoin.edu)

Office Hours: TBA

Communication: For all emails, please place “ECON 2555” in the subject line. I will try to respond to emails within 24 hours. Lecture notes and announcements will be posted on the course website. It is your responsibility to check your email and Canvas regularly for updates and announcements.

Textbook: The assigned textbook is *Intermediate Microeconomics with Calculus*, first edition by Hal R. Varian. It is *recommended but not required*. Older editions of *Intermediate Microeconomics: A Modern Approach* by Hal R. Varian can also be used and can be purchased online at a significant discount.

Course Description: This course is an intermediate-level study of contemporary microeconomic theory. It consists of three parts. First, we will cover the theory of rational choice and use it to analyze the choice problem that consumers face. In the second part, we will turn to the production decision faced by firms in a perfectly competitive market and study how markets can work to efficiently allocate resources through the price mechanism. The final part of the course will be devoted to understanding how markets can fail when the assumptions of the standard competitive model do not hold. We will also discuss the effects of government interventions to correct market failures.

2 Grading

The final grade is based upon

- Problem Set $\times 6$ ($6 \times 5\% = 30\%$)
- Exam 1 (20%)

- Exam 2 (20%)
- Final Exam (20%)
- Class Participation (10%)

Problem Sets: They include both theoretical and empirical questions to help you get familiar with the material. Solutions will be provided after submission.

Exam 1: close-book; in-class on 2/26; covers the material covered from 1/20–2/12.

Exam 2: close-book; in-class on 4/14; covers the material covered from 2/17–4/2.

Final Exam: close-book; location TBA, on 5/14; covers the material covered in the whole semester.

Letter grades are assigned as follows.

Score Percentage	Grade	Notes
[90, 100)	A	
[87, 90)	A-	
[82, 87)	B+	
[78, 82)	B	
[75, 79)	B-	
[?, 75)	C- to C+	I will give some version of a C even for scores that dip into the 60 percent range.
[?, ?)	D	A score below 60 percent is likely to earn a D.
[?, ?)	F	An F will only be given in rare circumstances, such as failing multiple assignments or demonstrating no effort in the course.

Non-graded Assignments: I will post optional practice problem sets (“worksheets”). These assignments are *not* graded and do *not* count directly toward your final grade. You are encouraged to complete them and submit them on Canvas to indicate completion. While correctness is not graded, consistent completion may be taken into account in borderline cases when final letter grades are determined. Completing these worksheets can therefore help, but will never hurt, your final grade.

3 Course Policies

Academic honesty. The relevant Honor Code clauses for this class include: “‘Academic Dishonesty’ includes but is not limited to (1) the receiving, giving, or using of any unauthorized assistance on quizzes, tests, written assignments, examinations or laboratory assignments;... (4) acquisition, without permission, of tests, computer files or similar material which would give the student an unfair advantage on an assignment or examination; (5) submission of academic work not a student’s own original effort.” More information can be found at: <https://www.bowdoin.edu/dean-of-students/student-handbook/the-academic-honor-code-and-social-code.html>.

Use of AI. You are not allowed to use ChatGPT or similar AI-powered tools to help with any assignment.

Late submission, extension, and makeup policies. Assignments submitted late will lose 10% of the points per day. Extensions may be granted if you contact me in advance with compelling reasons and supporting evidence. No makeup exams will be given except in cases of illness (confirmed by a doctor’s certificate), religious observance, participation in College activities at the request of the College authorities, or compelling circumstances beyond the student’s control. If at all possible, the student must inform me (or the Economics Department) of her/his situation before the exam.

Getting your learning needs met. Bowdoin College and I are committed to ensuring access to learning opportunities for all students. Please connect with me about any learning or personal challenges that arise for you over the semester that are impacting your engagement and learning in this course. I will honor any requests to reschedule an assignment or miss class due to the observation of religious holidays.

Students seeking accommodations based on disabilities must register with the **Student Accessibility Office**. Please discuss any special needs or accommodations with me at the beginning of the semester or as soon as you become aware of your needs; I am eager to work with you to ensure that your approved accommodations are appropriately implemented. If you have questions about requesting accommodations or concerns about approved accommodations, please contact Lesley Levy (llevy@bowdoin.edu), director of student accessibility, or talk with me at any time.

The **Baldwin Center for Learning and Teaching** offers peer-to-peer resources including mentors, Q-Tutors, and Writing Assistants. If you are multilingual you may also take advantage of Lisa Flanagan to work on writing and speaking assignments and projects. Tina Chong is available as an Academic Coach to work with you on goal setting, managing time, study habits and other strategies to support academic success ([link](#)).

The **Office of the Dean of Students** is also a resource for students facing personal and academic challenges. I encourage you to reach out to the people in the dean’s office for a meeting anytime.

Disclaimer. This syllabus is intended to give the student guidance in what may be covered during the semester and will be followed as closely as possible. I reserve the right to modify, supplement, and make changes as the course needs arise.

4 Schedule (Subject to Change)

Date	Topic	Chapter	Assignments/Notes
1/20	Introduction, Calculus Review	1	
1/22	Calculus Review (cont'd)		
1/27	Preference	3	
1/29	Utility	4	PS1 posted
2/3	Utility Maximization (I)	2, 5	PS2 posted
2/5	Utility Maximization (II)	2, 5	PS1 due in class
2/10	Utility Maximization (III): Intertemporal Choice	10	
2/12	Utility Maximization (IV): Applications		
2/17	Demand (I)	6	PS3 posted
2/19	Demand (II)	6	PS2 due in class
2/24	Demand (III): Income and Substitution Effect	6, 8	
2/26	Exam 1 (in-class, close-book)		
3/3	Technology (I)	19	
3/5	Technology (II)	19	PS3 due in class
	<i>Spring break!</i>		
3/24	Profit Maximization (I)	20	PS4 posted
3/26	Profit Maximization (II)	20	
3/31	Cost Minimization (I)	21	
4/2	Cost Minimization (II)	22	
4/7	Equilibrium and Surplus	14, 16	PS5 posted
4/9	Market Supply/Demand	14, 16	PS4 due in class
4/14	Exam 2 (in-class, close-book)		
4/16	Monopoly (I)	25, 26	
4/21	Monopoly (II)	25, 26	
4/23	Game Theory: Introduction	29	PS6 posted, PS5 due in class
4/28	Oligopoly	28	
4/29	Externalities (if time permits)	35	
5/5	Public Goods/Uncertainty (if time permits)	37	PS6 due in class
5/13	Final Exam (TBA)		